

ANI

NOT AT EASE Governor R.N. Ravi and CM M.K. Stalin with PM Narendra Modi at a convocation in Tiruchirappalli, January 2024

cratic accountability," says a senior state education official. "The state funds and runs these institutions. It should also guide their leadership."

When Ravi persistently withheld his assent to the bills, Tamil Nadu took the matter to the SC. In April 2025, the court ruled that governors cannot indefinitely delay state legislation, effectively deeming the bills passed. But, in May, the Madras High Court stayed their implementation, holding that education falls under the concurrent list, and the bills fell afoul of UGC regulations. Also, that they had not received presidential assent either. "It's circular logic," says a Chennai-based constitutional lawyer, voicing the frustration. For, the governor has to first reserve a bill for presidential assent. Tamil Nadu has returned to the SC to challenge the stay.

Between this legal thrust-and-feint, universities are stuck in a limbo. Three-member 'convenor committees', made up of a senior professor, an external expert and a state official, are filling in for V-Cs now. But they lack statutory powers. The result: a maze of delays. At MKU, for instance, the convenor also oversees two other institutions. Says C. Muniyandi of the faculty association: "Even for routine matters like staff salaries, university officials have to travel to Chennai multiple times to get a single file cleared. Promotions have stalled since 2022, for at least 85 faculty members."

Takeaways

- **A standoff between M.K. Stalin's DMK regime and Governor R.N. Ravi is roiling higher education in TN**
- **12 of the state's 22 public universities are without V-Cs for over two years now**
- **SC effectively cleared TN's bills to wrest power to appoint V-Cs from the governor. But HC stayed implementation**

The deadlock is also impacting students. Prince Gajendra Babu, an activist, says a scholar who completed his PhD in 2024 is unable to take up a postdoctoral offer in China. Only because there's no V-C to sign his degree. At UnoM, sources say, numerous PhD theses remain unevaluated. "Jobs, fellowships, career growth...everything is at a standstill. Who will take responsibility for these lost futures?" asks Babu.

There's a larger context. Tamil Nadu is one of the states that opposes the National Education Policy (NEP), arguing it imposes a monoculture on a diverse country. Thirugnanam, editor of education journal *Punnagai*, suggests the Centre is moving indirect levers to undermine Tamil Nadu's autonomy—threatening to withhold Samagra Shiksha funds, estimated to be around Rs 2,150 crore, unless it falls in line on NEP. "Administrative paralysis is not accidental; it is by design," he says. ■